

Topic 4.4 - Licensing, certification and appraisal

A real classroom situation

A province announces a reform. From next year, the annual self-evaluation that teachers have been completing for professional development will also be used to decide promotions.

The stated reasoning is efficient and sounds unanswerable: teachers already complete the form, the form is already aligned to the standards, and the province needs an evidence-based promotion process. Nobody is acting in bad faith.

Within one cycle, the forms change. Weaknesses stop appearing. The "areas for development" section fills with things that are safe to admit and irrelevant to improve. Mentors find their teachers no longer bring them real problems. The province now has an evidence-based promotion process and has destroyed the only honest record of teaching quality it had.

This topic is about why that was predictable.

Explanation

Teacher licensing and certification

Three terms get used interchangeably and are not the same thing.

Certification is the confirmation that a person has completed the required preparation and met the entry standard for the profession. It is usually awarded once, on completion of an accredited programme. Your B.Ed, accredited against

the National Professional Standards, is the mechanism by which you will be certified.

Licensing is permission to practise, issued by an authority, usually time-limited and renewable. Where licensing exists, it separates "was trained" from "is currently permitted to teach", and renewal can be made conditional on continued professional development. Not every system licenses teachers; many, including much of Pakistan's public sector historically, rely on certification plus employment rather than a distinct licence.

Appraisal is the periodic judgement of a serving teacher's practice. It recurs, and it is where most teachers meet the standards most often.

The distinction matters practically. Certification asks *was this person prepared?* Licensing asks *is this person currently fit to practise?* Appraisal asks *how is this person doing, and what next?* A system that runs all three through one instrument is asking one document to answer three different questions about three different time horizons.

The figure above maps where each lands across a career. Notice how many of the points are entry gates and how few are about the twenty-five years after them, which is the structural weakness of most teacher-quality systems: enormous attention to getting in, very little to what happens afterwards.

Appraisal, and the difference between formative and summative purposes

Isoré (2009), reviewing teacher evaluation across OECD countries, identifies the division that organises the whole field:

Formative appraisal exists to improve practice. Its question is what to work on next. For it to work, a teacher must be able to say "I cannot do this yet" without cost. Its natural evidence is Kashif's tally from Topic 4.3, and its natural output is a development plan.

Summative appraisal exists to reach a decision: confirm, promote, pay, or in serious cases remove. Its question is whether a threshold has been met. For it to work it must be comparable across teachers, properly evidenced, and appealable.

The requirements are not merely different; they are **incompatible in a single document**, which is what the bar across the figure marks:

- Formative appraisal needs candour; summative appraisal penalises candour.
- Formative appraisal is best done by someone trusted, ideally a mentor; summative appraisal must be done by someone with authority and distance.
- Formative appraisal should focus on the weakest area; summative appraisal invites a teacher to present their strongest.

A teacher facing one document serving both will resolve the conflict rationally, by treating it as summative, because that is the version with consequences. Everything formative is then lost. This is not a failure of professional maturity. It is what the incentive structure asks for.

A misconception this corrects: *appraisal and professional development are the same process.* They are related and must be connected, and they cannot be the same instrument. The connection is that the summative judgement should identify a need; the development work on that need then happens somewhere the teacher can be honest.

What happens when a standard is used for a purpose it was not designed for

The province in the vignette made a specific, common error, and Topic 4.1's four uses name it: a framework and an instrument built for continuing development were repurposed for accountability.

Three consequences follow, and they are predictable enough to be worth memorising.

The record degrades. Honest weakness disappears first. Within a cycle or two, the data the system relies on describes a teaching force with almost no development needs.

Behaviour optimises to the indicator. Where the indicator is a proxy, as Topic 4.2 discussed, the proxy gets produced. Displayed work appears the week before observation. This is the same mechanism as narrowing teaching to the test in Unit 3.

Trust between teacher and mentor is spent. A mentor who also reports on you is not someone you bring a problem to, and the mentoring relationship, which is the cheapest and most effective development mechanism a school has, quietly stops working.

None of this argues against accountability. A profession that cannot be held to account has no claim on public trust, which Unit 1 established. The argument is narrower and more useful: **accountability and development both work better when they are run through separate instruments that are connected deliberately**, rather than one instrument asked to do both.

What that separation looks like in practice is modest. A summative appraisal with clear evidence, comparability and a right of appeal, held perhaps annually. A separate, confidential developmental cycle of the kind in Topic 4.3, owned by the teacher, not collected. And a defined connection: the summative process may state a development priority, and the teacher's developmental work addresses it, without the developmental record itself becoming evidence.

Activity: Redesign the province's reform

Work in groups of four. The province wants an evidence-based promotion process and does not want to lose the honest developmental record. Both aims are legitimate.

Design the arrangement. Specify: what instrument is used for promotion and what evidence it draws on; what happens to the developmental self-evaluation; who sees each; and what the defined connection between them is.

Then, as a group, identify the weakest point in your own design: where would a determined administrator, or a determined teacher, be able to collapse the separation you built? Allow 30 minutes, and spend the last ten on that question.

Check your understanding

1. Distinguish certification, licensing and appraisal by the question each answers. (*Remember*)

2. Explain why formative and summative appraisal cannot be well served by one document. (*Understand*)
3. The province's reform was made in good faith. Explain, in sequence, what went wrong. (*Apply*)
4. Explain why a mentor who also reports on a teacher is less useful as a mentor, and what that costs a school. (*Analyze*)
5. Someone argues that separating development from accountability means teachers are never held to account. Identify what is wrong with that inference. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Certification confirms that a person was prepared; licensing, where it exists, confirms they are currently permitted to practise and can be tied to continued development; appraisal is the recurring judgement of a serving teacher. Most systems concentrate effort on entry gates and attend far less to the decades afterwards.

Appraisal serves two purposes with incompatible requirements. Formative appraisal needs candour, a trusted appraiser and a focus on weakness. Summative appraisal needs comparability, distance and appeal rights, and it rewards presenting strength. A single document serving both will be treated as summative, because that is the version with consequences, and the formative value is lost.

Using a development instrument for accountability predictably degrades the record, optimises behaviour toward proxy indicators, and spends the trust that makes mentoring work. The remedy is not to abandon accountability but to run the two through separate, deliberately connected instruments.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can distinguish certification, licensing and appraisal.

- ☐ I can state the requirements of formative and summative appraisal and show why they conflict.
- ☐ I can predict what happens when a developmental instrument is used for promotion.
- ☐ I can explain why the mentoring relationship is damaged by combined roles.
- ☐ I can describe a separation that preserves accountability rather than avoiding it.

Try this at your practicum school

Find out what actually happens in your practicum school's appraisal: who conducts it, what evidence is used, whether the outcome affects anything, and whether the same person mentors the teacher.

Write half a page identifying which purpose the process actually serves. Many schools will turn out to run a process that is formally summative and consequentially inert, which is a third case this topic does not cover: an appraisal that decides nothing. Consider what that does to how seriously it is taken, and whether it is better or worse than the province's error.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

Evaluate the province's reform and propose what it should have done instead.

Your answer must trace the mechanism by which the reform destroys the developmental record, distinguish the formative and summative requirements precisely, and propose a workable alternative that still delivers the evidence-based promotion process the province legitimately wants. Address the objection that maintaining two processes is unaffordable in a system already short of administrative capacity.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Mechanism (Analyze)	Traces the degradation step by step rather than asserting that morale falls
Command of the distinction	States the requirements of each purpose and why they conflict in one document
Alternative proposed (Create)	Delivers the province's legitimate aim rather than refusing it, and specifies the defined connection between the two processes
Cost objection (Evaluate)	Engages with administrative capacity honestly, rather than proposing a design that assumes resources the system lacks

Further reading

- Isoré, M. (2009). *Teacher evaluation: Current practices in OECD countries and a literature review* (OECD Education Working Papers No. 23). OECD Publishing. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED530786.pdf>
- Goe, L., Bell, C., & Little, O. (2008). *Approaches to evaluating teacher effectiveness: A research synthesis*. National Comprehensive Center for Teacher Quality, on matching an instrument to its purpose. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED521228.pdf>

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